Q+A

Spreading HER WINGS

Actor **Pooja Hegde** on working with Salman Khan, the South film industry and pressing ahead despite initial failures

Q. What are some lessons you learned while working with Salman Khan in *Kisi Ka Bhai Kisi Ki Jaan*?
Follow your gut feeling and be spontaneous. You prepare a lot and he'd be like, "Think on your feet, do something better." He is constantly pushing you. I have become a little more spontaneous as an actor.

Q. You play a Telugu girl in the movie. Is this Bollywood's way of catering to audiences in the South?
I don't think it was a deliberate attempt. It just comes from the fact that we wanted to tell a story. It's great that we are representing more people in our stories.

Q. Persistence seems to be your defining trait. You gave Miss India a second go and finished as the second runner-up. When your Hindi debut *Mohenjo Daro* (2016) didn't work, you headed South and made waves.
It comes from my parents, who are fighters. They have powered through life and made their careers. Watching them live their lives has been an inspiration. They always told me one failure or success doesn't define who you are.

Q. You are Mumbai-born and Mumbai-based but known for your work in Telugu and Tamil films. Are linguistic boundaries in India cinema disappearing?
It is great to be accepted by different audiences.... I just went where work was taking me. Yes, we are accepting great content in different languages and discovering some good stuff out there. Mind you, it was always there. It's just that you didn't indulge in blind tasting earlier.

with Suhani Singh



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